

# Cultural Sensitivity & Crisis Management: The D&G China Case

Session 6 · Case discussion — when a brand misreads a culture

Case: Hung & Ho (2019), *D&G's Marketing Missteps in China* · with HBR readings by  
Molinsky (2013) and Hahn & Molinsky (2018)

International Summer University<sup>WU</sup> 2026 · **Dr. Arne Floh**, WU Vienna

# About this session & the readings

One organisational faux pas, and the individual manager's playbook for preventing and recovering from your own. Readings (PDF) are in the course folder.

## The case

Hung, K. & Ho, M. (2019). *D&G's Marketing Missteps in China (A)*. Asia Case Research Centre, HKU. · [case-dg-china-marketing-missteps.pdf](#)

## Toolkit reading 1 — prepare

Molinsky, A. (2013). "Preparing for Inevitable Cultural Faux Pas." *Harvard Business Review*. · [molinsky-2013-preparing-for-cultural-faux-pas.pdf](#)

## Toolkit reading 2 — recover

Hahn, M. & Molinsky, A. (2018). "How to Recover from a Cultural Faux Pas." *Harvard Business Review*. · [hahn-molinsky-2018-recover-from-cultural-faux-pas.pdf](#)



# Learning objectives

---

- Explain why **humour and cultural elements** in advertising are high-risk across cultures.
- Use the **three Ms** (matter, media, manner) to diagnose an offensive campaign.
- Apply a **crisis-management** lens — the three phases, speed, and “stealing thunder.”
- Use **attribution theory / SCCT** to match a repair strategy to the type of crisis.
- Translate the lesson to the **individual** level: prepare for and recover from your own faux pas.
- Connect all of this back to **culture** — Hall, Hofstede and Meyer from earlier sessions.

# Watch first: the campaign that started it

Play the videos before we analyse them — watch your own reaction. D&G removed the originals; these are the third-party re-uploads cited in the case.

## VIDEO 1 · THE CAMPAIGN

### **“Eating with Chopsticks” — the three episodes**

A Chinese model eats pizza, cannoli and spaghetti with chopsticks as a narrator looks on.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TBFC5isQuYA>

## VIDEO 2 · BACKUP MIRROR

### **The same three-part series (mirror copy)**

Use if Video 1 is down. Watch for the details — the mispronunciation, the tone, the wrong Shanghai character.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=29AfMJymGu8>

## VIDEO 3 · THE CONTRAST

### **#DGLovesJapan — the campaign that worked**

Same brand, same idea of blending cultures — but warmly received. Why the difference? (Search this title if the link has moved.)

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bJXq3EVzd9g>

*Video 1 cited in Hung & Ho (2019) and verified live; the originals were removed by D&G, so these are third-party re-uploads. If a link has moved, search the titles above.*

THE CASE — SETUP

# D&G's Marketing Missteps in China

18 November 2018 — three videos, and 24 hours to a full-blown crisis



# D&G — brand snapshot

---

- Italian luxury house founded in **1985 in Milan** by Domenico Dolce and Stefano Gabbana; built on “Sicily, tailoring and tradition.”
- **Privately owned** — no external investors, so the founders design for the ultra-wealthy and “indulge their creative fantasies.”
- **Vertically integrated:** design, manufacturing and distribution in-house, with its own global store network.
- Revenue ≈ **€1.29 bn** (FY2018, flat year-on-year); net profit €60.5 m, down from €80 m the year before.
- The founders — especially Stefano Gabbana — were **active and outspoken** on social media.

# D&G in China — a market it could not afford to lose

---

- Entered mainland China in **2005** — the first Italian fashion company licensed to operate **without a local joint venture**.
- First flagship in **Hangzhou** (2005); by 2018, **40+ boutiques** across Greater China.
- China was both a key **market** and a source of **design inspiration** (the Chinese Palace collection, the qipao; ambassadors Karry Wang & Dilraba).
- Chinese shoppers were the **world's biggest luxury buyers** — about **one-third of global luxury spending** and ~65% of its projected growth to 2025 (McKinsey, 2019).
- Analysts' warning: up to **~30% of D&G's revenue** could be at risk if a China crisis were mishandled.

# The campaign: #DGLovesChina — “Eating with Chopsticks”

18 NOVEMBER 2018 · THREE SHORT VIDEOS TO PROMOTE THE FIRST-EVER SHANGHAI CATWALK (21 NOV)

- A Chinese model in a D&G sequined dress struggles to eat **pizza, cannoli and spaghetti with chopsticks**, against red lanterns and traditional music.
- A male narrator **lectures** her in a mocking tone — “Is it too big for you?” — and repeatedly mispronounces “Dolce” as “**Dos.**”
- Posted on Instagram, Facebook, Twitter **and Weibo**; hashtags #DGLovesChina and #DGTheGreatShow.
- Intended as **light comedy** — “an homage to China.” The reaction was the opposite.
- Under public pressure, D&G pulled the videos from Weibo within **24 hours** — but left them on Western platforms.



# Four questions frame our discussion

We work through the case in four moves — each part of the deck answers one question.

## QUESTION 1

### **Why were the videos offensive?**

The joke, the misreadings, and whether it could have been done better.

## QUESTION 2

### **Humour and the brand**

The advantages and risks of humour — and how to turn it around.

## QUESTION 3

### **Crisis communication**

How D&G responded, what it should have done, and how to prevent a recurrence.

## QUESTION 4

### **Repair & rebuild**

Repairing the damage and rebuilding the brand's long-term image in China.

QUESTION 1

# Why Were the Videos Offensive?

The intended joke, why China received it so differently — and whether it could have been done better



# The cultural misreadings

---

- **Chopsticks are a cultural symbol** — a Chinese invention taught from childhood. “Playing” with them reads as **disrespect**, not comedy.
- The model’s eyes were **artificially narrowed** — an **Asian stereotype** — and “is it too big for you?” carried a **sexist** undertone.
- The **condescending narrator** implied Chinese food and chopsticks were **inferior** to Italian cuisine and the fork.
- Mispronouncing “Dolce” as “Dos” **mocked the Chinese accent**; the on-screen “Shanghai” even used a wrong **Japanese kanji** font.
- **Outdated orientalism** (red lanterns) ignored modern, cosmopolitan China — “this is definitely not what China looks like now.”
- Historical irony: pasta is widely believed to **descend from Chinese noodles** (via Marco Polo).

# Intended vs. received meaning

A brand controls the message it **sends**, not the meaning the audience **makes** — and meaning is made through culture.

| Element                   | What D&G intended               | How China received it                         |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Chopsticks + Italian food | Playful East-meets-West comedy  | Mockery of a treasured cultural symbol        |
| The narrator              | Charming, tongue-in-cheek guide | Arrogant, colonial, talking down              |
| The model                 | Endearing, curious protagonist  | A demeaning Asian stereotype                  |
| “DGLovesChina”            | A love letter / homage to China | “They’ll take our money but look down on us”  |
| Traditional imagery       | Respectful nod to heritage      | Outdated, patronising view of a modern nation |

*Based on Hung & Ho (2019). Culture provides the schema through which audiences interpret advertising.*

# Diagnosing the offence — the three Ms

Controversial ads deliberately court strong emotion. Their offensiveness turns on three things (Prendergast & Ho, 2006).

## Matter

**What** is advertised. Luxury fashion is not inherently offensive — so this was not the problem here.

## Media

**Where** it runs. The more **public** the medium, the lower the tolerance — and global social media is as public as it gets.

## Manner

**How** it is conveyed — **the decisive factor**. People are offended more by manner than by matter. D&G's manner was the whole problem.

D&G's offence lived entirely in the **manner**: silliness, sexual undertones and a condescending tone — broadcast on the most public of media.

# Culture as the schema for meaning

---

- **Culture is the schema** audiences use to decode an ad — the same 30 seconds means different things in Milan and Shanghai.
- **High-context, collectivist** audiences (China) are **more critical** of sexual or socially negative appeals than low-context, individualist ones.
- Viewers judge offensiveness through their **cultural identity** — endorsing the video would have meant betraying it.
- This is Hall, Hofstede and Meyer in action: **power distance, high/low context and “face”** all shaped the reaction.
- **Could it be done better?** Yes — same brand, same idea, done with **relevance and respect** (see the #DGLovesJapan contrast). We return to this under Question 2.



QUESTION 2

# Humour and the Brand

Why humour fits — and endangers — a luxury brand, and how to turn the joke around



# Humour in advertising — a double-edged sword

Humour can be powerful — but every advantage has a matching risk that grows when the ad crosses cultures.

| Potential advantages                     | Risks — especially across cultures                |
|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| High message retention                   | It is genuinely hard to be funny                  |
| Grabs and holds attention                | If the joke misfires, the audience feels insulted |
| Creates a positive mood toward the brand | Humour does not build source credibility          |
| Distracts from counter-arguing the ad    | May be wrong for a prestige / luxury product      |
|                                          | Humour is subjective and deeply culture-bound     |

*Dahlen, Lange & Smith (2010); Tom & Catanescu (2001), via Hung & Ho (2019).*

# Turning the joke around

---

- Effective creativity needs **both** divergence **and** relevance: novel *and* meaningful, appropriate and valuable to **this** audience.
- D&G had plenty of divergence — but almost **no relevance** to how Chinese viewers see themselves.
- **Turn the joke on yourself.** Show a Western man clumsily eating Chinese soup with a knife — poke fun at **Italian**, not Chinese, culture.
- Tellingly, exactly such a **reverse parody** circulated on Weibo *after* the crisis — and Chinese audiences loved it.
- **Rule of thumb:** when using humour or cultural elements abroad, run it past **local eyes** before launch — test for offence on safe channels first.

QUESTION 3

# How Effective Was the Crisis Response?

What D&G did, what the moment demanded, and how to prevent a recurrence



# The response — and the clock

## What D&G did

Pulled the videos from **Weibo only** — no statement, no apology. Left them live on Western platforms. Then **let the debate simmer** for days as the catwalk approached.

## What the moment demanded

The Shanghai show was **days away**. Up to ~30% of **revenue** was exposed. China expected a **fast, sincere** response that showed the brand understood *why* people were hurt.

**The decision point (Case A):** a formal apology — now? On which channels? Said how? And should the show go on?

# Not the first time — a pattern of missteps

---

- **2012 — Hong Kong.** Guards barred locals from photographing the Canton Road store → protests; a formal apology came only after ~**10 days**.
- **2016 — spring campaign.** Chinese “tourists” taking selfies and shopping stirred unease about how China was portrayed.
- **2017 — #DGLovesChina hutong shoot.** Models beside poor locals in old alleys near Tiananmen — “it almost looks like North Korea!” A clash with the concept of **face**.
- **2018 — the videos.** The same blind spot, now amplified — and the founder had a track record of **controversial public remarks**.
- **Pattern, not accident:** a repeated failure to see modern China — and, as we will see, an **intensifying factor** in the crisis.

# The three phases of crisis management

Crisis management is not one moment of response — it is three phases (Coombs). Most of the work happens before and after.

**1**

## **Pre-crisis — prevention & preparation**

Anticipate crises, build a plan and a team, pre-draft messages, train spokespeople, connect local teams to HQ. D&G had little of this.

**2**

## **Crisis response — react**

Respond in the first hour: fast, accurate, consistent, and full of genuine concern for those hurt. This is where D&G stumbled badly.

**3**

## **Post-crisis — learn & rebuild**

Follow through on promises, repair the reputation, and prepare better for the next one.

# Speed, silence and “stealing thunder”

---

- A good initial response is **fast, accurate and consistent** — and expresses **concern** for those affected.
- **Silence is not neutral.** It lets others control the story and signals you have not grasped the situation.
- **Stealing thunder:** be the **first** to report and frame your own crisis — it measurably reduces reputational damage.
- **Social media compress the clock:** even a single “wrong” customer can turn a complaint into a movement within hours.
- **D&G’s failures:** a Weibo-only takedown, no timely statement, no local spokesperson, days of silence, and a late apology that felt **forced and insincere**.



# Attribution & SCCT: match the repair to the crisis

Situational Crisis Communication Theory: the more the public blames **you**, the more accommodative your response must be.

## Victim

Minimal responsibility — e.g. rumours, natural disasters. Instructions + care.

## Accident

Low responsibility — technical error, a challenge. Add excuse / justification.

## Preventable

**Strong responsibility** — organisational misdeed, human error. Needs **apology and/or compensation**.

D&G's scandal was a **preventable crisis** → strong responsibility. Worse, **intensifying factors** — a history of offending China and a controversial founder — magnified the threat. Excuses were never going to be enough; only **apology + compensation + genuine care** could work.

# Preventing a recurrence

---

- **Plan before the crisis:** a crisis-management plan, a named team (incl. a social-media manager), and **pre-drafted** message templates.
- **Connect local and HQ:** D&G's China team could not act; internal communication with Milan broke down.
- **Empower local voices:** encourage local staff to **speak up**, not passively follow global guidelines.
- **Test with local eyes:** put any campaign using humour or cultural content in front of **third-party** local reviewers.
- **Integrate social media** into every crisis scenario — monitor, respond in the right tone, on all channels, 24/7 if needed.
- **Be humble; act right away.** Listen first, acknowledge quickly, and treat even angry customers with care.

QUESTION 4

# Repairing and Rebuilding in China

From reputation-repair strategies to a long-term way back into the market



# Reputation-repair strategies — and what D&G needed

Benoit & Coombs' master list runs from defensive to accommodative. A preventable crisis calls for the accommodative end.

| Strategy                     | What it means                              | Fit for D&G?             |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>Deny / attack accuser</b> | "There is no crisis" / confront the critic | No — only for rumours    |
| <b>Scapegoat / excuse</b>    | Blame others; deny intent to harm          | No — reads as evasion    |
| <b>Justification</b>         | Minimise the perceived damage              | No — dismisses real hurt |
| <b>Compensation</b>          | Offer gestures of goodwill to those harmed | Yes — signals sincerity  |
| <b>Apology</b>               | Take full responsibility; ask forgiveness  | Yes — the core response  |

*Benoit (1995, 1997); Coombs (2007), via Hung & Ho (2019).*

# Rebuilding the brand in China

---

- **Localise the response:** use a Chinese PR agency and let **local staff lead** authentic, culturally fluent campaigns.
- **Test before you launch:** put every campaign with humour or cultural content in front of **third-party local reviewers**.
- **Empower local voices:** encourage local teams to **speak up** rather than passively follow global guidelines.
- **Balance global and local:** keep brand consistency, but drop the paternalistic, one-size-fits-all approach.
- **Diversify the team:** hire local talent and run internal **cultural-sensitivity training** — starting at the top.
- **Rebuild relationships** with consumers, retailers, celebrities, media and government — reputation is a long game.

# What happened next — beyond the (A) case

## THE CRISIS THE CASE STOPS JUST SHORT OF · 2018–2021

- **21 Nov 2018 — the messages.** Screenshots of Instagram DMs attributed to Stefano Gabbana insulting China leaked (via Diet Prada); D&G said both accounts were “hacked” — few believed it.
- **21 Nov 2018 — the show is cancelled** hours before showtime; models and brand ambassador Wang Junkai (Karry Wang) walked away.
- **21–23 Nov 2018 — delisted.** Chinese e-commerce platforms — Tmall, JD.com, Kaola, Vipshop, Secoo, Yoox — pulled D&G products.
- **23 Nov 2018 — the apology.** Dolce and Gabbana posted a ~90-second Weibo video, ending with both saying “对不起” (*duìbuqǐ*, “sorry”).
- **2019–2021 — no way back yet.** D&G sued Diet Prada in Milan (outcome unresolved); the 2021 Karen Mok backlash (~490 m Weibo views for merely wearing the brand) showed China had not forgiven it.

Sources: CNN Style, Fortune, SCMP, Business of Fashion, NBC News, China Daily (2018–2021). This is beyond the (A) case — full list on the references slide.

FROM THE FIRM TO THE INDIVIDUAL

# When You Make the Mistake

Molinsky (2013) and Hahn & Molinsky (2018): prepare for — and recover from — your own faux pas



# Prepare: have a “forgiveness strategy”

Mohammed, trained in deferential Saudi manners, came across as “weak” in a New York interview. We all slip abroad — so plan for it (Molinsky, 2013).

## Shape how it is read

Make your slip look like an **honest mistake by someone trying** — not proof you don’t care.

## Build swift trust

Show **authentic** interest in their culture. Learn how trust is actually built in that setting.

## Find a cultural mentor

A trusted local guide can **coach you ahead** of the moments that really count.

You already have a strategy for **learning** a new culture. Do you have a strategy for being **forgiven** in it?



# Recover: a five-step process

Mistakes are inevitable, so turn them into learning (Hahn & Molinsky, 2018).

1

## Ditch the obsession with performance

Swap a “performance mindset” for a **learning mindset** (Dweck). Stop catastrophising — mistakes are the raw material of learning.

2

## Equip yourself with knowledge

Learn the norms — and how people in this culture **react to** mistakes. Invest in relationships **before** you need them.

3

## Keep your cool

Assess the damage; if an apology is due, deliver one close to the local norm. A prior bond makes forgiveness far easier.

4

## Engage in self-reflection

Ask: what did I do, how did they react, what did I miss, what would I do differently? Write it down.

5

## Get feedback

Ask trusted locals what you’re missing; rehearse before high-stakes moments; lean on — don’t hide — your foreignness.

# Performance mindset vs. learning mindset

## Performance mindset

Mistakes = proof of your limits.

Thinking **constricts**; you become stiff and inauthentic.

**Catastrophizing**: “If I bow the wrong way, I’ll blow the deal!”

## Learning mindset

Mistakes = chances to improve.

You stay **loose, curious and authentic** — which is what actually builds relationships.

Improvement takes time, and will involve slip-ups along the way.

*The same idea scales up: D&G defended its “performance”; a learning organisation would have listened, reflected and adapted.*

# Key takeaways

---

- **Culture makes the meaning.** You control the message you send, never the meaning the audience makes — so test with local eyes.
- **Humour and cultural elements are high-risk abroad;** judge the **manner**, not just the matter, and be ready to poke fun at yourself.
- **In a crisis, speed and sincerity win.** Be first to frame it, apologise fully for a preventable crisis, and show genuine care.
- **Empower local voices** and prepare before the crisis — a plan, a team, and people who can say “this won’t work here.”
- **At the individual level,** carry a forgiveness strategy and a learning mindset — prepare for, and recover from, the faux pas you *will* make.

# In-class activity: draft D&G's response

## IN-CLASS ACTIVITY · 15 MINUTES · SMALL GROUPS

*Objective: put the crisis-communication frameworks to work under time pressure.*

- 1 You are D&G's **crisis team**, 24 hours after the videos. Classify the crisis (SCCT) and name the **intensifying factors**.
- 2 Draft a **90-word public statement** for Weibo: fast, accurate, consistent — and full of genuine care.
- 3 Decide: does the Shanghai show **go ahead**? On which **channels** do you respond, and who is your **spokesperson**?
- 4 Name **two prevention measures** so this can't recur — and connect one to your own market-entry group assignment.

*Be ready to read your statement aloud — the class will judge whether it “steals thunder” or fans the flames.*

# Further sources

Beyond the case and teaching note — for the crisis outcome and the market context.

## The crisis & its aftermath (2018–2021)

CNN Style (2018). *D&G cancels Shanghai show amid ‘racist’ ad controversy*.  
Fortune (2018). *Online stores in China are dumping Dolce & Gabbana*.  
South China Morning Post (2018). *Chinese e-commerce sites remove D&G products*.  
NBC News / China Daily (2018). *D&G founders’ video apology*.  
Business of Fashion (2018). *Assessing the damage after the D&G uproar*.  
BoF & CNN Style (2021). *Chinese netizens still haven’t forgiven D&G* (Karen Mok).

## Market data & frameworks

McKinsey (2019). *China Luxury Report* — Chinese consumers  $\approx$  one-third of global luxury spending;  $\sim 65\%$  of growth to 2025.  
Bain & Company. *What’s powering China’s market for luxury goods*.  
Coombs, T. *Crisis Management & Communications* (SCCT), Institute for Public Relations.  
Benoit, W. L. (1995). *Accounts, Excuses, and Apologies* — image restoration.  
Prendergast & Ho (2006). *Offensive advertising* — the three Ms.



DEPARTMENT OF GLOBAL TRADE · WU VIENNA

**Dr. Arne Floh**

Senior Lecturer in International Marketing  
Deputy Program Director MSc Export- and Internationalisation Management

[arne.floh@wu.ac.at](mailto:arne.floh@wu.ac.at)

Welthandelsplatz 1, 1020 Wien, Austria

**[www.wu.ac.at](http://www.wu.ac.at)**